CHAPTER 8

THE EFFECTS OF WHAT YOU REMEMBER AND WHAT YOU KNOW ON LEADERSHIP PROCESSES: HOW MEMORY WORKS, HOW WE ACCESS WHAT WE KNOW, AND THE ROLE OF IDENTITY LEVELS

Summary

Memory plays a key role in our ability to accurately rate leaders, and for our ability to access our own leadership skills. Measures of leadership that emphasize processes associated with episodic memory (of separate, contextualized events) rather than semantic memory processes (abstractions from multiple events) can be especially useful in understanding and developing leadership. The nature of our leader identities, which can focus on the individual, relational or collective level, influences our likelihood of engaging in leadership behaviors.

Chapter Outline

Key Aspects of Memory

How Do Memory Systems Relate to Leadership

Memory and Leadership Ratings

How Leadership Identities Aid Knowledge Access for Action

Personal Semantics and Leadership

Personal Semantics and Memory Access

Leadership and Performance

Skills and Leadership

Team Performance and Leadership

Identity Level and Leadership

Identity Levels

Identity Level and Leadership Development

Measurement of Dynamic Identity Structures

Your Personal Identity

Potential Group Differences in the LSCS-R

Implications for Your Leadership

Identity Level

Leadership Identity

Leadership Operating Through Others

Conclusions

Learning Outcomes

By the end of the chapter, readers should:

1. Understand how memory operates and the key distinction between semantic and episodic memory processes.
2. Be aware of their highest LSCS-R identity and motivational orientation scores and the potential effects of these on their own perceptions of others, and use of social and task skills.
3. Be able to describe their own leader identity level and how it influences their own behavior and how others view them.
4. Be able to identity whether and how their own leadership behaviors affect the identity levels of others.

Personal Development Activities

Working alone or in small groups, describe some specific interactions that you have had which involve leadership (in these interactions, you might have taken the role of the leader, a

follower, or simply an observer). Consider what level of identity (individual, relational, collective) the key persons in these interactions likely held. Were those persons acting from similar or different identities? How might the interaction outcomes have been different if the identity levels differed? You might want to try role playing the same interaction multiple times whilst adopting different identity levels.

Table 1. Six Subscales of the Levels of Self-Concept Scale – Revised.

Instructions: For each of the following statements listed, indicate the degree to which it describes you, using the response scale shown below. Once you have responded to all of the items, then sum the scores for each 5-item subscale and divide the total by 5.

Response scale anchors: **1= Strongly Disagree; 2 = Disagree; 3 = Slightly Disagree; 4 = Neither Agree nor Disagree; 5 = Slightly Agree; 6 = Agree; 7 = Strongly Agree**

Scale Dimensions and Corresponding Items	Your Response
Individual Identity (II)	
1. I delight in my personal successes.	
2. I thrive on work where performance depends on my own merit.	
3. I often get absorbed in tasks simply because they are important to me.	
4. I do best when I have more say in how I work.	
5. I appreciate work that helps me grow as a person.	
II Score: Sum your responses to items 1-5, then divide the sum by 5	
Comparative Identity (CI)	
6. I feel best about myself when I perform better than others.	
7. I have a strong need to know how I stand compared to my co-workers.	
8. I often compete with my co-workers.	
9. I welcome opportunities to show that my abilities are better than my co-workers.	

10. I often search for information that lets me compare myself to others.	
CI Score: Sum your responses to items 6-10, then divide the sum by 5	
Relational Identity (RI)	
11. When I think of myself, I focus on the people who are a part of me.	
12. My relationships with others drive how I feel about myself.	
13. People close to me shape who I am.	
14. I put a lot of effort into maintaining relationships.	
15. My ability to perform well depends upon my relationships with others.	
RI Score: Sum your responses to items 11-15, then divide the sum by 5	
Concern for Others (CO)	
16. It is highly important to me to uphold commitments to significant people in my life.	
17. I value friends and co-workers who are caring and empathetic.	
18. I would help a friend or co-worker having a personal problem, even if it meant using my own time or money.	
19. Caring deeply about a close friend or relative is very important to me.	
20. I feel worthwhile when my actions benefit someone with whom I have a personal relationship.	
CO Score: Sum your responses to items 16-20, then divide the sum by 5	
Group Identity (GI)	
21. I judge myself by the standards of groups that are important to me.	
22. I respond intensely to what people say about groups to which I belong.	
23. I defend the values and norms of organizations to which I belong.	
24. I share many characteristics with others in my work group.	
25. I define myself by being a member of groups that are important to me.	

GI Score: Sum your responses to items 21-25, then divide the sum by 5	
Group Achievement (GA)	
26. When I become involved in a group project, I do my best to ensure its success.	
27. I feel great pride when my work group does well, even if I'm not the main reason for its success.	
28. When I'm part of a team, I am focused on the whole group rather than myself.	
29. I would be honored to represent my organization at important events.	
30. I value chances to contribute to work or social organizations.	
GA Score: Sum your responses to items 26-30, then divide the sum by 5	

Table 2. Your score compared to LSCS-R average scale scores for different reference groups

LSCS-R Scale	**My Score**	**Self-Identified Gender**		**Adult Age Groups**			**Supervisory Experience**	
		Male	**Female**	**Young**	**Middle**	**Older**	**Yes**	**No**
II		3.90	3.88	3.95	3.87	3.92	4.00	3.68
CI		2.88	2.68	3.00	2.75	2.52	2.89	2.57
RI		3.22	3.33	3.36	3.26	3.12	3.36	3.10
CO		4.05	4.22	4.05	4.14	4.25	4.19	4.02
GI		2.60	2.64	2.75	2.57	2.58	2.68	2.49
GA		3.89	3.97	3.87	3.93	4.05	4.05	3.69
Group Size		358	328	163	457	66	453	233

Self-reflection on your own typical identity levels.

As you consider the information just presented, it may be helpful to look back at the self-ratings that you recorded in the "My Score" column of Table 2 and address the following questions.

Which level of identity (that is, the Individual Identity, Relational Identity or Collective Identity subscale score) received the highest value? Do you think that this identity level has shaped the way you see others, the skills that you have developed and normally use, or the way that you feel about things?

My highest LSCS-R Identity score was _____.
How has it affected my:
Perceptions of others?

Use of skills?

Feelings?

Then look back at your motivational orientation scores in Table 2 (that is, the subscales of Comparative Identity, Concern for Others, Group Achievement). Which orientation received the highest score? Was the highest rated motivational orientation consistent with your expectations? What do you believe are the strengths and weaknesses of this motivational orientation for your current leadership situation?

My highest LSCS-R Motivational Orientation score was _____.

How has it influenced aspects of my motivation:
Task effects?

Social effects?

Self-reflection on your use of identities for leadership.

To see the personal relevance of these points, think back on some of your most recent leadership experiences. You might find it helpful to consider some or all of the following questions.

Which identities were active for you?

What type of identities did you prime in others?

Did you typically create an environment that emphasizes learning, or did it emphasize performance and avoiding errors?

How do you think your leadership identity level has affected your leadership behavior and the way you are perceived by others?

How has it affected your motivation as a leader?

Links to Other Chapters

See Chapter 7 for additional information on how memory can influence the developmental feedback given to leaders.

See Chapter 10 for another important factor (i.e., context) that should be considered in the measurement of leader performance.

Key Reading

Ibarra, H., Hildebrand, C. A., & Vinck, S. (2023). The leadership odyssey. *Harvard Business Review, 101(3)*, pp. 102-110.

Further Reading

Day, D. V. (2024). Self-views and leader development. Chapter 4 in *Developing leaders and leadership: Principles, practices and processes*, pp. 95-126, Palgrave Macmillan.

Other Recommended Sources

For a slightly different but very complementary perspective on leader identity, see the Youtube video, "The new psychology of leadership: Why and how leaders need to care about group identity." From a presentation by Alexander Haslam (University of Queensland). https://youtu.be/nwcf_E9pUUA?si=JpfCsQ_yCJMOJ4sP